

SIX WAYS TO BE CRAZY.

You rejected two hooks. The research says you were right both times, and for a reason neither of us had named.

1,400+

ACTIVE INDIAN
JEWELLERY
ADS
SELLING
DISCOUNT

~0

SELLING
ENTERTAINMENT

3%

WEIGHT
COMMENTS
NOW CARRY
(WAS ~15%)

2.4 → 1.9

STAR RATING WITH
A CHARACTER
VS WITHOUT

THE DIAGNOSIS

Both hooks I wrote were textbook “**left-brain**” advertising — isolated product feature, on-screen text, voiceover, no character, no place, no dialogue. System1’s study of 200 ads found those are precisely the features that correlate with *failing*. Over 80% of ads never clear the threshold below which business impact is roughly zero. **You were reacting to something real.**

Pieces Bold Nocturne Bracelet ₹1,999 · Charm Box Chain ₹2,149

Decide pick one — I rebuild the full shoot card around it

Read time 6 minutes

WHY THE LAST TWO WERE WRONG.

Four findings. The first two explain the rejections; the second two decide what replaces them.

1 · The features I used are the features that fail

Orlando Wood's *Lemon* (IPA/System1, 200 ads) splits advertising into **left-brain** features — flatness, isolated product features, on-screen text, voiceover, abstraction — and **right-brain** features: whole scenes, **characters**, a sense of place, dialogue, humour, expressions, cultural reference. The finding is blunt: *“the greater the number of left-brain features, the less likely the ad is to achieve a strong Star rating.”* Star rating predicts market-share growth. **More than 80% of ads never clear 3 stars, below which business impact is minimal or zero.**

My two scripts had: a product feature in macro, on-screen spec chips, a voiceover, no character, no room, no dialogue, no other person. That is the losing list, almost item for item.

2 · “Salesmanship” actively suppresses the thing that makes ads work

System1 × TikTok × WPP Media's 2026 *Creator Effectiveness Playbook* — 1,217 paid ads, 8 markets, 182,550 respondents, ~\$70m of spend — separates **showmanship** (characters, storytelling, humour, recognisable environments) from **salesmanship** (on-screen text, hard CTAs, facts and figures). Showmanship raises emotional response. **Salesmanship reduces it by 7–12%.**

My last script was wall-to-wall salesmanship: spec chips, price chips, a fact stack, a hard CTA. Also from the same study: **the most entertaining creator ads score 2.7 stars against 2.2 for the least entertaining**, and entertainment *“levels the playing field across creator size”* — a small creator with a funny idea beats a big creator with a boring one. That is the whole argument for Sejal.

A CORRECTION I OWE YOU

I justified both scripts partly on *“it has to work on mute — most people watch without sound.”* That figure is from the Facebook-feed era. **Instagram's own data is that roughly 80% of Reels are watched with sound ON.** I built a constraint into two scripts on a number that doesn't apply to the format we're making.

It changes the brief: design so the *visual* gag still lands silently, but **write the line as the payoff and stop neutering the audio.** Captions stay — they lift completion — but as dialogue and punchline cards, not spec bullets.

3 · A recurring character is the highest-return decision available

System1's work on **fluent devices** — a character or bit reused across a campaign:

Average star rating	2.4 vs 1.9
More likely to grow market share	+37%
More likely to grow profit	+30%
Brand recognition	92% vs 86%
Share of US ads currently using one	~4%

Usage has collapsed from 41% of IPA effectiveness entries in 1992 to about 4% today — so it is both the best-evidenced structural choice and an abandoned one. At ₹3,000/day it is also the cheapest: **a character gets more effective every time it runs, at no extra production cost.** The Indian proof is right there — Kusha Kapila built a career on one aunty, Dolly Singh on one mother, both invented from inside a media office with no budget.

4 · Build for the forward, not the comment

Instagram's ranking signals have moved. **Sends per reach — DM shares — carry roughly 3–5x the weight of a like** for reaching non-followers, because a share is a personal vouch. **Comments have fallen to around 3% of ranking weight, from ~15% in 2023.**

My “Guess which one” hook was engineered to farm comments. It was optimising a signal that has collapsed. In India specifically, the share trigger is a Reel that lets the sender say something about a *third person* — *this is literally you, this is literally my mother*. Every concept below is built to be forwarded to a family WhatsApp group.

AND THE COMMERCIAL CASE, WHICH IS STRONGER THAN I REALISED

A live Meta Ad Library pull across the Indian jewellery category found **GIVA running ~423 active ads, Palmonas ~678, Rubans ~127** — and almost every one of them is selling a percentage off. **Entertainment-led paid creative in this category is effectively an empty lane.** Even the Indian brands with famously funny organic voices run boring paid ads. Being funny here isn't an indulgence; it's the only uncontested position left at your price point.

SIX CONCEPTS. PICK ONE.

Every one is shootable by Sejal alone, with a phone, a tripod and one afternoon. No crew, no actors, no props budget. Every one has a character, a room and dialogue — the three things the last two scripts were missing. And in every one, the joke cannot exist without the product, which is the condition under which humour helps direct response rather than hurting it.



Bold Nocturne ₹1,999 — elongated paperclip links, one pavé-set. Reads like a ₹10,000 piece.



Worn. Bold, chunky, gold. This is the hero — it stops a scroll where the chain doesn't.



Charm Box Chain ₹2,149 — fine box chain, barrel charm. Delicate; better as the second beat.

OKAY, THAT'S HOW THESE ADS USUALLY GO

DEVICE — CATEGORY PARODY, THEN THE REAL THING · BERNBACH SELF-AWARENESS

Opens on: black and white, wobbly, over-acted. Sejal fighting a flimsy chain, losing, flinging it off-frame. Text card: "TIRED OF JEWELLERY THAT GIVES UP?"

Smash to full colour, normal room, normal voice: "Okay — that's how these ads usually go. Here's the actual thing."

Then she just shows it. One-handed lobster clasp click in close-up. *"It's 18K gold-plated over surgical steel, it's nineteen ninety-nine, and I haven't taken it off since I got it."*

Why this one. It parodies the exact demonstration format you rejected twice — and then delivers the demonstration anyway. So it is simultaneously the crazy ad and the rational ad, which means it carries the least downside risk of anything on this list. The humour—product fit is total: the joke is *about* jewellery ads, so it cannot be lifted off the product.

SHOOT

Two setups, one room

RISK

Low — hedged by design

REUSABLE

Moderately

THE BRACELET COMMITTEE

DEVICE — RECURRING CHARACTER · SAAS-BAHU · RULE OF THREE

Opens on: a dining table shot from above. Three empty chairs. One bracelet on a saucer in the middle, like evidence.

Hard cut. Sejal in chair one, dupatta over her head: "The committee will now examine the bracelet."

Chair two, different drape, adjusting glasses: *"Is it gold?"* Chair one: *"It is 18K gold-plated. Over surgical steel."*

Chair three says nothing, picks it up, holds it to the light, nods once. Chair one: *"Approved."*

Why this one. This is the campaign, not the ad. The Committee can convene on every SKU you will ever launch — and the fluent-device evidence says that is worth half a star, +37% on share growth and +30% on profit growth, at zero extra production cost. Three costume beats, one tripod, one table. **If you want one decision that pays for three years, it is this one.**

SHOOT

Three setups, one table

RISK

Lives on the performance

REUSABLE

Forever — highest

03

TYPES OF PEOPLE WHO ASK WHERE YOU GOT IT

DEVICE — THE NATIVE INDIAN “TYPES OF...” FAST-CUT · ARCHETYPES

Opens mid-sentence, no preamble — she is already talking.

“Type one —” hard cut, she’s a colleague leaning in, whispering: **“oh my GOD where is this from.”**

“Type two —” she’s an aunty, suspicious, already grabbing the wrist: *“asli hai?”* *“Type three —”* a cousin, reaching for the clasp: *“ek din ke liye de de.”* Final shot, flat to camera: *“Bold Nocturne. Nineteen ninety-nine. Type three is not getting it.”*

Why this one. The most reliably performing native structure on Indian Reels, and the lowest execution risk here — each cut is a change of *posture*, not costume. It also disposes of the “is it real gold” objection inside the comedy rather than arguing with it. Built to be forwarded: every viewer knows a Type Three.

SHOOT

Four angles, one wall

RISK

Low

REUSABLE

Yes, as a format

04

ONE PROBLEM

DEVICE — BERNBACH FLAW-ADMISSION · OPEN LOOP

Opens on: Sejal holding up the bracelet. Face completely serious. No music.

“I need to be honest about this bracelet. It has one problem.”

Long beat. She looks off-camera. *“It makes every other thing I own look like it isn’t trying.”* Cut: she dumps a fistful of thin, sad chains into a drawer and shuts it. *“Sorry.”*

Why this one. Volkswagen’s *Lemon* in twenty-eight seconds. It opens by promising a *negative*, which no jewellery ad ever does, and that is a genuine curiosity gap rather than a manufactured one. It is also **the most elegant concept here** — the one that keeps the brand looking like itself while the writing does the work. If “crazy” worries you, this is the one.

SHOOT

Two setups

RISK

Lowest brand risk

REUSABLE

As a line format

05

BECAUSE WE HAVE A PROBLEM

DEVICE — TRUE FACT, DELIVERED DEADPAN, THEN THE REGISTER DROPS

Opens on: extreme close-up of the clasp. Flat, clinical voice. Hands in frame.

“This is surgical stainless steel.”

Pull back to an ordinary bedroom. *“It’s the grade of steel they use for things that go inside people.”* Beat. *“We plated it in 18K gold and made a bracelet out of it. Because we have a problem.”* Cut: she’s wearing it, entirely normally, drinking chai.

Why this one. It uses the single most underused true fact in your catalogue — it is in your own product copy and no competitor is saying it. The comedy is the register drop, not a gag, so the brand never looks silly. Zero props.

SHOOT

Three setups, one room

RISK

Low

REUSABLE

As a voice

06

SINCE MARCH

DEVICE — BATHOS · THE POSITIONING STATED AS A JOKE

Opens on: a slow, reverent push toward two cupped hands holding the chain, like a temple offering. Silence.

Whispered: “It has been in our family since... March.”

Cut to an ordinary living room, ordinary light, flat to camera: *“I bought it in March. It’s twenty-one forty-nine. But it looks like an heirloom, and honestly that’s the whole job.”*

Why this one. The register drop is both the joke and the positioning statement — and it is legally clean, because “looks like an heirloom” is a claim about appearance, not about value or material. It is also the only concept here that leads with the chain rather than the bracelet.

SHOOT

Two setups

RISK

Low

REUSABLE

Limited

AND WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

IF YOU ONLY SHOOT ONE

Shoot 01 — “Okay, that’s how these ads usually go.” It is the only concept that is crazy *and* keeps a working product demonstration inside it, so if the comedy doesn’t land the ad still sells. Given the last two attempts missed your taste, I’d rather hand you something with a floor.

But build 02 — The Bracelet Committee. The evidence on recurring characters is the strongest structural finding in any of this research, and almost nobody uses it any more. One aunty, reused across twelve ads, is worth more than twelve clever one-offs — and every future script starts half-written instead of blank.

The honest caveat on all of this

Binet & Field’s IPA work — 1,200+ case studies — found emotional campaigns deliver very large business effects on new customers in **31%** of cases against **5%** for rational ones. But their actual prescription is a **split, not a replacement**: emotional creative wins long-term, rational creative still drives short-term response.

So the crazy ad is not a substitute for a product ad. **Run one of these alongside a plain, well-made demonstration cut** — which is essentially the script I already wrote, and which is now worth keeping rather than deleting. The mistake was making it the *only* thing, not making it at all.

Three things that are true whichever you pick

1. **The bracelet leads, not the chain.** I finally looked at the product photography: the Bold Nocturne is bold, chunky and reads like a ₹10,000 piece. The Charm Box Chain is delicate. The gap between how the bracelet looks and what it costs *is* the idea — and both my earlier scripts led with the chain.
2. **The music is a legal gate, not a taste decision.** Every currently-trending Indian audio is unusable in a paid ad — Instagram listing a sound does not mean Meta licensed it. Budget for Epidemic or Artlist, or build on original voice and foley. **Decide before the shoot.**
3. **Ship more than one.** These are cheap enough to shoot two or three in one afternoon. At roughly one winner per twenty-four creatives, a single hero with no variants is the one plan that reliably fails.

Tell me which and I’ll build it

Pick a number and I’ll rebuild the full package around it — beat sheet, shot list, Sejal’s read sheet, caption file, compliance pass. If none is right, say which is *closest* and I’ll go again: these six are drawn from fifteen, and the rest are on the bench.

WHAT STAYS TRUE REGARDLESS

Never “waterproof” · never “18K gold” for plated stock · a tap, never a pool · no wear-log claim she can’t support · any spoken price carries the ₹150 delivery · #Ad in the top third for a third of the runtime · no named competitor · no false urgency. ASCI reviewed influencer ads in FY26 and found **97% broke the rules** — almost all of it disclosure. It is ten seconds of work to not be in that number.